importance of this king. He rebuilt the Somnath temple, repulsed a number of Turkish raids and constructed one of the largest forts in the world at Mandu in Madhya Pradesh. However, his most visible legacy is the huge lake that he created using an earthen dam in Bhopal, a city that is also named after him. Before the infamous industrial accident of 1984, the city of Bhopal was best known for this body of water. It is a testimony to the skills of the medieval engineers that the lake still exists a thousand years later. It is proof that big dams work well in the Malwa plateau. Tectonics and silt often make them unwise in the rest of India.

Farther north, the Chandelas of Bundelkhand were originally feudatories of the Gujara–Pratiharas but carved out a small but vigorous kingdom for themselves when the latter went into decline in the tenth century. They celebrated their successes by building the famous temples of Khajuraho, a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The Kandariya Mahadev temple, the largest in the complex, is said to have been built after the Chandelas succeeded in fending off Mahmud Ghazni himself.

All discussion about Khajuraho tends to focus on the erotic sculptures that adorn some of the temples. However, if one actually visits the temples, it is quickly apparent that the most striking sculptures depict lions or lion-like dragons. Several of them are shown locked in mortal combat with a Chandela king or warrior (occasionally women warriors). Just like the Mauryan emperors, the Chandelas liked to use the lion as a symbol of their power. Equally telling is the total absence of tigers in the sculptures. I found this particularly intriguing given that Panna Tiger Reserve is barely a twenty-minute drive away from Khajuraho. Was this lion country during medieval times? Or, was the tiger simply not considered a worthy symbol of royal power?

For a century and half after Mahmud’s raids, the Turks were largely restricted to West Punjab. If anything, there was a sense of complacency. That changed in 1192 when Muhammad Ghori defeated Prithviraj Chauhan, the Rajput king of Delhi and Ajmer, in the Second Battle of Tarain (150 km from Delhi in the modern state of Haryana).